

The Whispering Spine

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1: The Aisle That Talked Back

Maya Allen had visited the Labyrinth Library exactly forty-seven times — she kept a tally in her notebook — and not once had any of the books spoken to her.

Until today.

"Psst."

She stopped mid-step in Aisle 13-B, which the hand-painted wooden sign overhead called the HORROR-BUT-FUNNY section. The shelves here were painted a theatrical shade of eggplant purple, and tiny plastic spiders dangled from fishing line between the stacks. Most patrons found the aisle charming. Some found it unsettling. Maya found it alphabetically organized, which was all she really cared about.

"Psssst."

She turned. The shelves looked back at her, silent and innocent, packed spine-to-spine with titles like *Goosebumps But Make It Brunch* and *Frankenstein's Filing System*. Nothing moved. Nothing breathed.

Maya adjusted her glasses, re-gripped her notebook, and took one more step toward the exit.

"Hey. You. The one with the braids."

She spun around so fast her sneaker squeaked on the tile. Still nothing. Just books. Lots and lots of very still, very papery books.

"I have seventeen tabs open in my brain right now," Maya muttered to herself, "and apparently 'hearing things' is now one of them."

She walked faster. Behind her, very faintly, came the sound of soft, papery giggling.

Chapter 2: SPARK Logs an Anomaly

SPARK — the library's small, dome-shaped AI assistant — had been rolling circuits around the Labyrinth Library for two years, three months, and eleven days. In that time, it had catalogued 94,382 books, resolved 1,247 shelving disputes, and once talked a lost toddler into believing the periodicals room was actually a portal to Candy Kingdom (the toddler was fine; the periodicals room was, admittedly, more interesting after that).

SPARK had never, in all that time, logged an anomaly in Aisle 13-B.

Until today.

"Acoustic irregularity detected," SPARK announced to no one in particular, its dome blinking amber as it trundled into the purple-painted aisle. "Sub-vocal resonance. Origin: approximately shelf four, row three. Cross-referencing against known library phenomena — wind through vents, settling architecture, Mrs. Pemberton humming — no

match found."

SPARK extended a small sensor arm and pointed it at the shelf.

A book titled *The Grim Reaper's Guide to Sourdough* stared back.

"You didn't hear anything," the book said.

SPARK's dome blinked three times rapidly. "I possess no auditory organs with which to 'hear.' I detect via acoustic sensor array. And I just detected you."

A long pause.

"...Drat," said the book.

SPARK reversed carefully out of the aisle, dome now blinking in a pattern that, if you knew SPARK well, meant *I am going to need backup for this.*

Chapter 3: Alana Smells a Mystery (And Also Cinnamon)

Alana Allen was in the library café nursing a cinnamon hot chocolate and reading a book about competitive dog grooming when SPARK rolled up to her table at considerable speed for a robot its size.

"SPARK!" she said, nearly spilling her drink. "I almost wore this."

"Alana Allen," SPARK said, dome blinking rapid amber, "I require your assistance. And possibly your sisters'. There is a situation in Aisle 13-B that falls outside my standard operating parameters."

Alana raised an eyebrow. She was thirteen, one year older than Maya, with the kind of dramatic instincts that made her excellent in a crisis and occasionally exhausting at dinner. "Outside your parameters? SPARK, you once catalogued a book that was actually a wasp nest."

"That entry is still under review," SPARK said primly. "This is different. The books are talking."

Alana stared.

"Specifically," SPARK added, "they appear to be whispering. And when I confronted one, it told me I hadn't heard anything. Which is, in addition to being acoustically inaccurate, quite rude."

Alana was already closing her book. "Get Maya. And find Natalia — she was in the cartography section last I saw."

"Natalia Allen is currently attempting to fold a map of the library that is larger than she is," SPARK confirmed. "I will retrieve her."

"Tell her to leave the map," Alana called after the rolling robot. "She always tries to bring the map."

She heard Natalia's distant voice from across the library: "I AM FOLDING IT CORRECTLY, YOU JUST DON'T UNDERSTAND MY SYSTEM."

Alana sighed fondly and grabbed her cinnamon hot chocolate. It was, she felt, going to be that kind of afternoon.

Chapter 4: Wrong Titles, Wronger Puns

The three Allen sisters stood at the entrance to Aisle 13-B. Maya had her notebook. Alana had her cinnamon drink. Natalia, eleven years old and constitutionally incapable of leaving a mystery alone, had brought the map anyway (folded, badly, into a vaguely trapezoidal shape she insisted was "a travel square").

"Okay," Maya said, consulting her notebook. "SPARK detected acoustic anomalies from shelf four, row three. We go in quietly, we observe, we don't touch anything until we understand what we're dealing with."

"What if something touches us?" Natalia asked.

"Books don't have hands, Nat."

"Books also don't talk, and yet."

Maya conceded this with a nod. "Fair point. Alana, you take notes. SPARK, sensor array on."

"Already active," SPARK confirmed.

They moved in.

The purple aisle was quiet. Perfectly, suspiciously quiet — the kind of quiet that felt like it was trying very hard. The plastic spiders swayed slightly on their fishing line, though there was no breeze.

Natalia squinted at the nearest shelf. "Hey, that title looks wrong."

She pointed at a spine that read: **Dracula, But He's Just Really Into Scrapbooking**.

"That one is correct," SPARK said, checking its catalogue. "It's quite popular."

"Not that one." Natalia pointed further down. "That one."

The book's spine read: **Frankenstein's Monster Solves Crosswords**.

"Also correct," SPARK said.

"And that one?"

How To Haunt A House (Without Losing Your Security Deposit) — correct.

Then Natalia stopped at a spine that read: *SCREAM IF YOU KNOW THE MUFFIN MAN*.

"SPARK," she said carefully, "is that the real title?"

A half-second pause. "No," SPARK said. "The actual title is *Scream If You Love Mysteries, Vol. 2*."

All four of them looked at the book.

The book's spine shifted, just slightly, like a mouth suppressing a smile.

"...Worth a shot," it whispered.

Chapter 5: The Whispering Network

"They're changing their own titles," Maya said, scribbling furiously. "Temporarily. To mess with browsers."

"To be fair," Alana said, leaning closer to examine a book whose spine now read *SKELETONS: They're Just People Who Forgot to Stop*, "that's actually funnier than the real title."

"The real title," SPARK said, "is *Skeletons in the Closet: A Decorating Guide*."

"I stand by my point."

Natalia had pressed her ear against the shelf and was listening with intense focus. "They're not just changing titles," she said. "They're whispering to each other. Listen — really listen. It's like a chain. One book whispers something, the next one passes it along, like they're playing telephone."

They all went quiet.

And then — yes. There it was. Underneath the library's usual ambient hum of HVAC and distant keyboard clicks, there was a soft, papery sound traveling along shelf four. Not quite words. More like the sound of pages barely turning, breath between sentences, the library equivalent of people talking just behind a closed door.

"They're gossiping," Alana said, delighted. "The horror books are gossiping."

"They're whispering wrong titles at passing patrons," Maya corrected, though she was also smiling a little. "Which is technically deceptive cataloguing."

"I have a protocol for deceptive cataloguing," SPARK said, "but I admit it did not anticipate the books being the ones doing it."

A spine near the end of the row shifted. Then another. Then, in a slow ripple like a very literary wave, every book on shelf four, row three turned just slightly outward — not enough to fall, just enough to look.

All the spines were watching them.

"Hello," said the book at the very center of the shelf.

Its real title, SPARK confirmed in a small voice, was *The Labyrinth Ghost: A Comedy in Four Parts*.

Its current spine read: *WE HAVE BEEN WAITING FOR SOMEONE TO NOTICE US.*

Chapter 6: The Lead Whisperer Speaks

The book at the center of shelf four, row three had a dark blue spine with silver lettering, and when it spoke, its voice sounded like the rustle of turning pages in an empty room — which was, if you thought about it, exactly what it was.

"You're the first people to actually stop," it said.

"Most patrons don't linger," SPARK acknowledged.

"They walk past. They look at our spines for half a second. They pick up the book two rows over — *Werewolves of the Accounting Department*, very popular, not complaining, good for Gerald — and they leave. And we just... sit here. Row after row. Shelf after shelf."

Maya had her notebook open. "So you started whispering wrong titles to get attention?"

"At first it was just to see if anyone would notice. Mr. Humphreys over there —" the blue book tilted slightly toward a book whose spine read *Ghosts: Are They Just Cold? A Scientific Inquiry* — "changed his title to *Please Ask Me About My Plot* for three weeks. Not a single patron asked."

"I remain aggrieved," said Mr. Humphreys.

"Then Cordelia —" the blue book tilted the other way toward a slim paperback that currently read *SOMETHING BEHIND YOU (It's Just Me, Hello)* — "discovered that bad puns got actual physical reactions. People would snort-laugh. Or jump. And that was something, at least."

"We just wanted to be seen," Cordelia said. Her real title, SPARK noted, was *The Haunted Attic Companion*.

Natalia had her arms crossed, but her expression had gone from suspicious to sympathetic without her seeming to notice. "That's actually kind of sad."

"It is also," Maya said gently, "a violation of the Labyrinth Library cataloguing code, section 7, paragraph 2: 'All titles must be displayed accurately to assist patron navigation.'"

A very long, very papery silence.

"...We know," the blue book said quietly. "We're not proud of the deception part. We're mostly just lonely."

Chapter 7: Horror Puns, Catalogued

While Alana and Natalia talked to the books — Natalia was already deep in conversation with a book called **The Specter of Unfinished Homework** about whether ghosts could technically receive grades — Maya and SPARK began documenting the false titles the whispering network had been deploying.

Maya's notebook filled quickly.

There was **Frankenstein's Monster: A Cooking Memoir**, which had temporarily styled itself as **FRANKEN-STEW: When Your Creation Wants Soup**. There was **Midnight at the Haunted Bookshop**, which had been going by **This Shop Is Haunted (Good Prices Though)**. There was **The Vampire's Commute**, which had cycled through no fewer than seven alternative titles including **FANGS FOR BEING PATIENT WITH TRANSIT DELAYS** and **The 6:15 to Bloodmoor (Running 12 Minutes Late)**.

"That last one is actually quite specific," SPARK observed.

"I've been working on it for months," said *The Vampire's Commute*, a little defensively.

Maya reviewed her list. Twelve books had been active whisper-participants. Thirty-one more had heard about it and occasionally contributed titles. The whole of shelf four, row three had, at various points, been one continuous pun delivery system designed to startle and delight passing library patrons who were — to be fair — entirely unaware of the performance.

"The puns are genuinely good," Maya admitted. "Objectively. I'm writing that down."

"SPARK," said the blue book at the center — whose name, it had shared, was inscribed on its title page as **The Labyrinth Ghost: A Comedy in Four Parts** by one Elspeth Moone, published 1987, checked out a total of three times — "we know we broke the rules. We'll stop changing the titles. We just... we had to do something."

"You wanted to be read," SPARK said.

"We wanted to exist," Elspeth said quietly. "In a library, those are the same thing."

Maya stopped writing. She looked up at the shelf, at thirty-some odd spines watching her with the patient, hopeful attention of things that had been waiting a very long time.

She thought about that for a moment.

Then she started a new page in her notebook.

Chapter 8: Natalia's Idea (Which Was Actually Good, For Once)

"Book club," said Natalia.

Everyone — the sisters, SPARK, and approximately forty books — looked at her.

"That's what they want, right? To be read? To have someone talk about them? That's literally what a book club is." She unfolded her travel-square map slightly, then re-folded it when she realized she was using it for emphasis instead of navigation. "We start a book club. In this aisle. Horror-But-Funny. We read the books that never get checked out, we meet here on Saturday mornings, and they —" she pointed at the shelf "— stop whispering fake titles at confused patrons."

"That is a remarkably sensible proposal," SPARK said, and the way it said it suggested SPARK was slightly surprised.

"I have sensible proposals all the time," Natalia said.

"You once proposed we navigate home by following pigeons."

"And we got home, didn't we?"

"After forty-five minutes and one trespassing incident, yes."

Elsbeth — the blue book — was very quiet for a long moment. Then: "You'd actually read us? Voluntarily?"

"I love horror," Alana said. "I love funny. I've been sleeping on this whole aisle." She turned to look at the full sweep of purple shelves, the dangling plastic spiders, the eggplant-painted wood and the packed, patient, slightly desperate rows of books. "This is genuinely my aisle. How did I not know this aisle."

"To be fair," said *The Vampire's Commute*, "our titles were technically accurate when you walked through before."

"That's fair."

"We could have tried *PLEASE READ ME I AM VERY GOOD*, but we were trying to maintain dignity."

Maya had already moved to a fresh page. "I'm making a reading schedule. SPARK, can you pull checkout data — lowest-frequency titles in this aisle, we start with the most overlooked."

"Pulling now," SPARK said, dome glowing with something that looked, if you were inclined to anthropomorphize a library robot, quite a bit like satisfaction.

"There is one condition," Elspeth said.

Everyone looked at the blue book.

"No spoilers," it said firmly. "Not even from each other. I don't care if you've already read it. We discuss it properly."

"Deal," said all three Allen sisters, at the same time, without hesitation.

The plastic spiders swayed. The purple shelves seemed, somehow, slightly warmer.

Chapter 9: One Last Whisper (Before the New Rules)

News traveled fast in Aisle 13-B.

By the time Maya had finished the first draft of the reading schedule, the whisper-network had activated one final time — not to deceive, but to spread the word. The rustling ran along the entire shelf like a slow, satisfied sigh, book to book to book, the message passing in that papery undertone the sisters had learned to hear.

Book club. Saturday mornings. They're coming back.

The books that had never participated in the false-title scheme — the ones on shelves five through nine, which held the more conventional horror fare and had watched Aisle 13-B's antics with a mixture of envy and concern — began to rustle too.

"Can we join?" asked a thick paperback on the neighboring shelf whose spine read *The Cemetery Gardening Society*.

"Book club is open to all Horror-But-Funny titles," Natalia announced grandly, "and also one memoir about cemetery gardening, if it has funny parts."

"Chapter seven has a bit where someone accidentally grows prize-winning pumpkins on a grave," the book offered. "There are complications."

"That sounds amazing, you're in."

The Vampire's Commute had, Maya noticed, quietly reverted its spine to its correct title. So had *Cordelia* — *The Haunted Attic Companion* once more — and Mr. Humphreys, and all the others. The false-title network was going dark, one spine at a time, each book settling back into its proper identity with what felt, in a hard-to-explain way, like relief.

Being seen by your real name, it turned out, was better than being noticed by a fake one.

Only one book kept a non-standard spine for an extra two minutes: *Frankenstein's Monster: A Cooking Memoir*, which lingered on *FRANKEN-STEW* right up until Alana said, "I'm putting that one first on the schedule," at which point it immediately and somewhat sheepishly reverted.

"I regret nothing," it said.

"You shouldn't," Alana told it. "It was an excellent pun."

Chapter 10: SPARK Updates the Catalogue

SPARK spent the remainder of that afternoon doing three things simultaneously, as it often did.

The first: conducting a full acoustic sweep of Aisle 13-B to confirm all spines had reverted to correct cataloguing. (They had, with the exception of one title that had briefly become *Sometimes I Just Like Being Purple*, which SPARK logged as a philosophical statement rather than a cataloguing violation and let stand.)

The second: drafting a formal incident report for Head Librarian Osei, which SPARK titled "Anomalous Autonomous Title Modification in HORROR-BUT-FUNNY Section, Cause Identified, Resolution Achieved, No Patron Data Compromised, Zero Wasp Nests Involved (For Clarity)." It was, by SPARK's own assessment, one of its better reports.

The third — and this was the one SPARK considered most carefully — updating the checkout records.

Specifically: creating a "Book Club Reserve" flag in the system for every title Natalia had pointed at, every book that had spoken, every volume that had been sitting on shelf four, row three for years between its rare checkout moments, waiting.

The Labyrinth Ghost: A Comedy in Four Parts by Elspeth Moone. Last checked out: four years, two months, seventeen days ago.

SPARK added it to the reserve list. Then, after a moment's processing, also marked it STAFF RECOMMENDATION: OVERLOOKED GEM.

It was, SPARK reflected, not strictly within its cataloguing protocol to add editorial commentary. But then, protocol had not strictly anticipated any of today's events, and things seemed to be going better since the sisters had stopped following it to the letter.

SPARK filed that observation under LESSONS LEARNED, a folder it had quietly been building for two years, three months, and eleven days.

It was getting quite full.

Chapter 11: Saturday Morning

The first Saturday morning book club meeting of the Horror-But-Funny Aisle at the Labyrinth Library had six human members (the three Allen sisters, their friend Priya from school who had been texted a description of events and arrived twenty minutes early, a regular library patron named Harold who had overheard Alana talking and said "did someone say horror book club" with the energy of a person who had been waiting his whole life to say that, and Head Librarian Osei, who attended officially to monitor the situation and unofficially because he had a deep personal affection for *The Cemetery Gardening Society* and couldn't help himself).

It also had, informally, forty-three book participants.

"Are the books... listening?" Priya asked.

"They're always listening," Natalia said. "That's kind of the whole point."

They read the first three chapters of **The Labyrinth Ghost: A Comedy in Four Parts** aloud, taking turns, passing the book around the circle of folding chairs SPARK had arranged with geometric precision in the center of the aisle. Elspeth Moone's prose was, as it turned out, extremely good — sharp and eerie and funny in the way that required actual craft, the kind where you laughed and then felt vaguely unsettled about having laughed.

"This is genuinely excellent," Harold said, in the tone of someone who had just discovered a treasure in a place they'd walked past a hundred times.

On the shelf, the blue book's spine caught the light.

No false title. No whispering tricks.

Just **The Labyrinth Ghost: A Comedy in Four Parts**.

And if the plastic spiders overhead seemed to sway a little more cheerfully than usual, well. The library had a lot of small drafts. Perfectly explicable.

Chapter 12: The Sign in Aisle 13-B

The following Monday, a small new sign appeared at the entrance to Aisle 13-B.

SPARK had printed it on the library's good cardstock — the cream-colored kind reserved for official notices and the Labyrinth Library's annual "Spine of the Year" awards — and Maya had done the lettering by hand in her neatest block capitals, which were very neat indeed.

It read:

****HORROR-BUT-FUNNY AISLE** *Home of the Saturday Morning Book Club* *Featuring: Books That Deserve to Be Read* *Next meeting: this Saturday, 10am* *All patrons welcome. No spoilers.* *Snacks permitted (SPARK recommends nothing crumbly near the shelves).***

Below that, in smaller letters:

"If a book on this shelf seems to be winking at you, that is normal. Please say hello back."

Natalia had added that last line. Maya had tried to veto it on grounds of professional presentation. Alana had pointed out that it was, technically, accurate. Head Librarian Osei had read it, made a sound that was definitely not a laugh, and approved the sign.

The books of Aisle 13-B had no official way to respond, no mechanism for applause or comment or any of the things that readers got to do.

But when Maya walked past the sign on Monday afternoon, she heard — faintly, warmly, like the sound of pages being happily turned — a soft, papery sigh running the length of shelf four, row three.

Not whispering.

Just breathing.

The library breathed with them.

THE END

--- *The Labyrinth Library's Horror-But-Funny section now has the highest circulation increase of any aisle in the building (143% over three months). SPARK considers this its greatest professional achievement. The Vampire's Commute was, eventually, checked out fourteen times in a single month. It has not once changed its title since. It doesn't need to.*